

Architectural styles

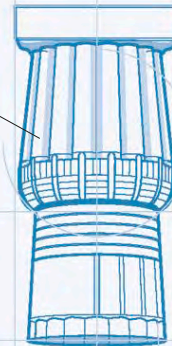
ANCIENT EGYPT

Although the pyramid is the most recognizable building type of ancient Egyptian architecture, a range of extraordinary temples and palaces also survive, generally as a result of their massive size and robust construction from stone.

The ancient Egyptian civilization came into existence around 3000 BCE, before beginning to decline around 1000 BCE, and ending with the death of Cleopatra in 30 BCE. Its strength and longevity rested on its utilization of the River Nile for large-scale agriculture, which created the wealth and stability necessary for society and culture to flourish and to undertake construction projects often on a colossal scale.

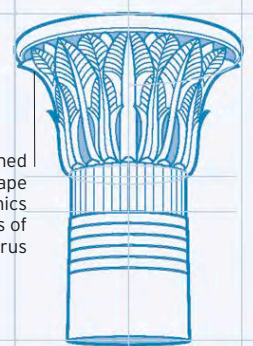
Egyptian architecture made extensive use of stone and mud-brick, generally relying on a post-and-lintel construction system. Flat roofs constructed of huge stone slabs required closely spaced columns to carry the load. Surfaces, including columns and entrance pylons, were highly decorated with hieroglyphics and motifs deriving from Egyptian religion. Though our knowledge of ancient Egypt's architecture is informed by the survival of mostly religious buildings and tombs, hieroglyphics tell us a large amount about Egyptian society, daily life, history, and the central importance of their religion.

shape based
on a closed
lotus flower



LOTUS BUD

fanned
shape
mimics
fronds of
papyrus



PAPYRUS

△ LOTUS BUD AND PAPYRUS CAPITALS

A capital is the uppermost part of a column that plays out to support the load above. In Egyptian architecture, capital forms were typically derived from plants that held significance in Egyptian culture, such as the lotus bud and papyrus.

◁ COLOSSUS OF RAMESSES II

A colossus is a massive statue of a pharaoh or deity. One of many at Karnak, this colossus commemorates Rameses II, often known as Rameses the Great.



granite Colossus of
Rameses II at entrance
to Hypostyle Hall

statuette of Meritamen,
daughter of Rameses II
and later his principal wife

columns of
reddish-brown
sandstone

Hypostyle Hall ceiling
supported by 134
internal columns

Kiosk of Taharqa,
used for public
ceremonies

vertical groove
would have
housed wooden
flag pole

▽ SPHINXES

A sphinx is a mythical creature, usually combining a lion's body with a human's head. It acted as a guardian at the entrance of a temple. The most famous sphinx, the Great Sphinx of Giza (see p.208), is 240 ft (73 m) long and 66 ft (20 m) high.

Amun is
associated
with rams

statuettes of
Rameses II stand
between forelegs
of sphinx

entrance pylons
remain unfinished
and of unequal height

Temple of Amun
measures 1,200 x
360 ft (366 x 110 m)

